Maungdaw-Buthidaung. Despite mounting several counterattacks, Allied troops in Buthidaung and the Kalapanzin valley were cut off. On May 11, 1943, the Allied offensive ended with British and Indian troops retreating to India. Despite having overwhelming numerical superiority, better artillery, as well as a monopoly in tanks, the offensive ended in complete failure. A second Allied offensive into Arakan fared better. Allied troops were able to capture the port of Maungdaw. Before the Allies could launch another offensive, the Japanese 55th Division counterattacked. Unlike the first Arakan offensive, the Allies stood firm and were able to inflict heavy casualties on the Japanese. The offensive came to an end at the onset of the monsoon season.

The threat of further Allied offensives from India forced the Japanese to strengthen their forces in Burma. On March 27, 1943, three Japanese armies —the 33rd Army in Upper Burma, the 15th Army in central Burma, and the 28th Army in the south—were consolidated into the Burma Area Army (BAA). The BAA was then tasked with the mission to defend Burma. In May 1943, the 54th and 55th Divisions were formed in Japan and then transferred to Burma under the command of the BAA. In January 1944, the 2nd Division left the Solomon Islands and was reconstituted in Burma as the 28th Army with the 24th Brigade. In April 1944, the Imperial General Headquarters (IGHQ) in Japan activated the 33rd Army to defend Upper Burma. The 56th Division, the 18th Division, the 53rd Division, and a part of the 49th Division were incorporated into the newly created 33rd Army.

## THE TURNING POINT—THE BATTLES OF KOHIMA AND IMPHAL

The Japanese did not originally have plans to advance into Assam and invade India at the onset of World War II, but Lieutenant General Renya Mutaguchi convinced the Japanese Minister of War, Hideki Tojo, that the only way to eliminate the Allied aerial threat to Burma was to control northeastern India. This would create a buffer zone between India and Burma. By controlling northeast India, the Japanese could then cut off the Allies aerial supply route over the Himalayas to China, thereby completely cutting off all Allied supply operations to China.